

English

Year 9

Cambridge Lower Secondary
Student Manual



Prime Books · English Year 9 · Student Book

First edition, 2026

Published by Prime Books, the publishing imprint of Prime School, www.primeschool.pt

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British English edition.

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INTRODUCTION

How this book works

This is a book about how texts work on their readers. In this first unit you will read the opening of an original mystery, work out its genre from its features, and study the structural choices, including what the writer deliberately refuses to tell you.

What makes this book different

- **Everything is original.** Every sentence, example and diagram was made for this book.

- **Every claim is checked.** Facts come from real, cited sources; every numerical answer was executed by computer before publication.

- **Thinking is taught explicitly.** Dedicated panels show you how specialists in this subject actually reason.

A note to teachers and parents

This book follows the spirit of an international lower-secondary programme, interpreted afresh for Prime School. Each topic opens with clear outcomes and closes with self-assessment, so progress is visible to pupil and teacher alike.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Reading the page

Each section follows the same rhythm, so you always know where you are.

PANEL	WHAT IT DOES
Learning outcomes	What you will be able to do by the end.
Getting started	A warm-up that wakes up what you know.
Key words	The vocabulary of the topic, defined.
Worked example	A model solution, with the reasoning shown.
Questions	Practice, from straightforward to demanding.
Did you know?	A true and surprising fact.
Summary checklist	'I can' statements to check your progress.
Sources & references	Where every fact came from.

How to work

Read with a pencil in your hand. When the book asks a question, try to answer it before reading on. Do the work in your notebook, and check your reasoning, not just your answer.

GETTING SET UP

Before Unit 1

You need a pencil, a ruler, a notebook and your curiosity. Anything else this unit requires is listed where it is needed.

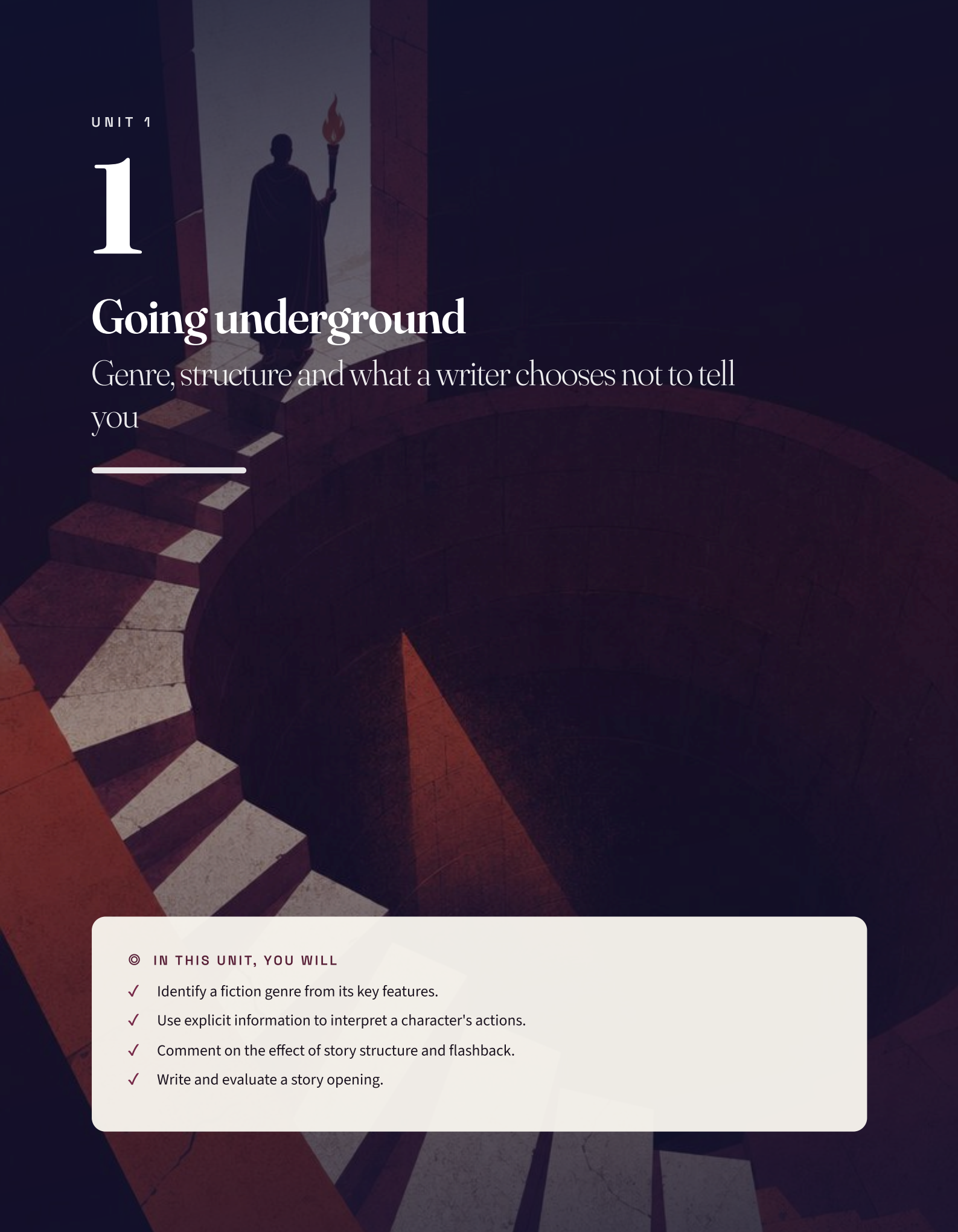
Your toolkit

- A notebook for working, planning and recording, not just for final answers.
- The habit of checking: recalculate, reread, and ask whether the answer is sensible.
- The confidence to say "I am not sure yet", which is where all real learning starts.

A quick self-check

- 1 What do you already know about this topic?
- 2 Which part of it do you expect to find hardest, and why?
- 3 How will you know when you have genuinely understood something, rather than just recognised it?

Unit 1 begins now. Work carefully, check honestly, and ask good questions.

A dark, atmospheric illustration of a figure in a black robe holding a flaming torch, standing on a spiral staircase that descends into a deep, dark well. The scene is dimly lit, with the torch providing the primary light source, casting long shadows and highlighting the stone steps and walls.

UNIT 1

1

Going underground

Genre, structure and what a writer chooses not to tell you

© IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- ✓ Identify a fiction genre from its key features.
- ✓ Use explicit information to interpret a character's actions.
- ✓ Comment on the effect of story structure and flashback.
- ✓ Write and evaluate a story opening.

◆ GETTING STARTED

A story opens with someone going down a staircase they have been warned about. In pairs, discuss:

- what genre do you expect, and what made you expect it?
- what has the writer already made you feel, with almost no information?
- what is the single most powerful thing a writer can withhold?

UNIT 1 • SESSION 1.1

Reading fiction: genre and setting

Learn

A **genre** is a type of story with recognisable features. Readers use those features to form expectations within a sentence or two, and skilled writers play with those expectations deliberately.

“ EXTRACT • 'THE CISTERN' (OPENING)

They reached the cistern faster than Ines had expected, which she did not like. Nothing about this had been slow so far, and slow was how she preferred her mistakes.

"Down there," said Bruno, and the torchlight went with his arm. "The Cartographer says you are the one who can read it."

It flashed through her mind that she had never told him her name. She had been careful about that, careful for eleven months, and now here she was at the mouth of a hole in the ground with a man who knew what she could do.

"Be back here at nine tomorrow night," he said. And with that, he was gone.

She knew she would be there.

1 Which genre of fiction do you think 'The Cistern' belongs to? Discuss in pairs, considering:

- the title
- the names of the characters
- the setting
- the events so far

- the mention of "The Cartographer"

2 Writers give **explicit information**: details stated directly. In the first four paragraphs you learn that Ines is cautious, that she has been hiding something for eleven months, and that she has an ability someone wants. Write a paragraph explaining:

- how this information helps you understand her decision at the end
- what you think might happen later in the story

■ KEY WORDS

- **genre**: a particular type of text, such as adventure, crime or science fiction.
- **fiction**: stories about imaginary characters and events.
- **setting**: the location and time in which a story takes place.
- **explicit information**: ideas and details that a writer states directly.

UNIT 1 • SESSION 1.2

Story structure and flashback

Learn

Structure is the order in which a writer reveals things, and it shapes the reader's experience as powerfully as the events themselves. A writer chooses when to introduce a character, how to handle time, and what to hold back.

A **flashback** is a section that goes back in time to explain something. Used well, it answers one question while raising another.

■ KEY WORD

- **flashback**: a part of a story that goes back in time to explain an event.

1 In pairs, discuss these structural choices in 'The Cistern' and the effect each has on the reader:

- opening at the moment of arrival, rather than the journey there
- the single-sentence paragraph "She knew she would be there."
- revealing that Bruno knows her name **after** the dialogue, not before
- naming "The Cartographer" but explaining nothing about them

2 In groups, discuss your reactions to this opening. Talk about:

- whether the story interested you, and why
- what you thought of the structure
- whether you were more interested in Ines or in what is down the hole

SPEAKING TIP

In a group discussion, make well-judged contributions: build on what someone else has said, or challenge it with a reason. Developing the discussion matters more than being first to speak.

PEER ASSESSMENT

Review your contribution to the group discussion.

- How thoroughly did you explore the points raised?
- Which of your comments helped develop the discussion most effectively?

- 1 Write a summary of the different viewpoints expressed by members of your group. Structure your writing using a subheading for each of the three bullet points you discussed.

UNIT 1 • SESSION 1.3

Writing a story opening

Learn

Your turn. The craft in the extract is mostly **restraint**: it withholds more than it explains.

- 1 Plan an opening of your own. Decide:
 - your genre, and the two features that will signal it immediately
 - one piece of explicit information that will matter later
 - one thing you will deliberately withhold
 - where your opening will stop
- 2 Write your opening, in 200 to 300 words, ending on a line that makes the reader need the next page.
- 3 Annotate your own opening: mark one structural choice you made, and write one sentence explaining its intended effect.

▲ CHALLENGE YOURSELF

Rewrite your final paragraph so it appears **first** instead. Does your opening become stronger or weaker? Write three sentences justifying your preferred version.

☑ SUMMARY CHECKLIST

- ✓ I can identify a fiction genre based on a story's key features.
- ✓ I understand how explicit information helps a reader understand a character.
- ✓ I can comment on the effect of story structure and flashback.
- ✓ I can express my opinion of a story opening and summarise my own and others' ideas.

UNIT 1 • FINAL PROJECT

The opening that cannot be put down

★ FINAL PROJECT

The opening that cannot be put down

Refine your story opening until a reader genuinely has to turn the page. It should be 250 to 350 words, and every structural choice in it should be deliberate.

What to hand in

- Your polished opening, with a title.
- An annotation marking two structural choices and their intended effects.
- A one-paragraph note on what you deliberately withheld, and why.

How it will be judged

Criterion	Weight	---	---
Effectiveness of the opening	35%		
Deliberate control of structure	30%		
Quality of the annotation and reflection	20%		
Accuracy of expression	15%		

UNIT 1 • CHECK YOUR PROGRESS

- 1 What is a genre, and how do readers use genre features? [2]
- 2 What is explicit information? Give an example from 'The Cistern'. [2]
- 3 Explain the effect of the single-sentence paragraph 'She knew she would be there.' [2]
- 4 What is a flashback, and what can it achieve? [2]
- 5 Explain why withholding information can be more powerful than revealing it. [2]
- 6 Name two features that would signal the crime genre in an opening. [2]

UNIT 1 • EVALUATION

Be honest. Colour the circle that matches how you feel about each outcome: green means confident, amber means nearly there, red means needs more work.

I CAN ...	GREEN	AMBER	RED
identify a fiction genre from its key features	☐	☐	☐
use explicit information to interpret a character	☐	☐	☐
comment on the effect of structure and flashback	☐	☐	☐
write and evaluate a story opening	☐	☐	☐

UNIT 1 • WHAT CAN YOU DO?

✓ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Identify a fiction genre from its key features. | ☐ Comment on the effect of story structure and flashback. |
| ☐ Use explicit information to interpret a character's actions. | ☐ Write and evaluate a story opening. |

GLOSSARY

Unit 1

genre: a particular type of text, such as adventure or crime.

fiction: stories about imaginary characters and events.

setting: the location and time in which a story takes place.

explicit information: ideas and details a writer states directly.

flashback: a part of a story that goes back in time to explain an event.

SOURCES & REFERENCES

Where everything came from

All text and diagrams are original to this edition. The factual claims can be checked here. Links were live as of July 2026.

S UNIT 1 • GOING UNDERGROUND

1 'The Cistern'. An original story opening written for this book. © Prime School 2026.

1 Genre in fiction. The conventions readers use to form expectations of a text.

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Genre_fiction

What a writer withholds.

This Year 9 Student Book studies the craft of restraint. You will identify genre from key features, use explicit information to interpret character, comment on structure and flashback, and write an opening a reader cannot put down.

Written for Prime School pupils, in clear British English, with original fiction written for this book.

GENRE

STRUCTURE

FLASHBACK

DISCUSSION

WRITING